# WAVERLEY GATEWAY GUIDE

*Connecting International Capital with Emerging & Frontier Markets*

# MAURITANIA

Africa

*Information current as of November 2026*

Dialogue | Trust | Partnership

office@lordwaverley.com
www.lordwaverley.com

## WHERE AND HOW TO ENTER

### KEY INVESTMENT LOCATIONS

| Location / Region | Strategic Importance | Priority Sectors |
|---|---|---|
| Nouakchott | Capital and largest city; seat of government, the central bank and the main commercial port | Services, construction, logistics, financial services |
| Nouadhibou | Economic capital and deep-water mineral port shipping SNIM iron ore to Europe and China; centre of the fishing industry and home to the Nouadhibou Free Zone | Port logistics, fisheries and seafood processing, industry |
| Offshore gas basin (Greater Tortue Ahmeyim and BirAllah) | GTA LNG, shared with Senegal, reached its 2.7 mtpa nameplate capacity in December 2025, with up to 36 cargoes targeted in 2026; the BirAllah field holds an estimated 60–80 trillion cubic feet | LNG, gas-to-power, oilfield and marine services |
| Zouérat / Tiris Zemmour (north) | Iron ore heartland of state miner SNIM, which produced a record 14.7 million tonnes in 2025, linked by rail to Nouadhibou | Iron ore mining, rail logistics, mining services |
| Tasiast (Inchiri region) | Kinross's wholly owned gold mine, which produced 503,429 gold-equivalent ounces in 2025 | Gold mining, mining services, power supply |
| Green hydrogen projects (national) | The AMAN project's convention, signed in September 2026, provides for up to 18 GW of renewables and about 1.2 million tonnes of green hydrogen a year | Solar and wind power, green hydrogen and ammonia, green iron |
| Senegal River valley (south, Rosso) | Main irrigated farming belt and principal land crossing to Senegal and West African markets | Agriculture, agro-processing, cross-border trade |

### INVESTOR ENTRY ROUTES

- Agence de Promotion des Investissements en Mauritanie (APIM), the national investment promotion agency, operating a digitised one-stop shop (Guichet Unique) for company registration and work permits
- Investment Code (Law No. 2025-006 of 19 February 2025), strengthening protection against expropriation, guaranteeing foreign-currency availability and capital transfers, and offering tiered incentives such as reduced import duties on equipment and training tax credits
- Green Hydrogen Code (Law No. 2024-037), under which large projects sign a global convention setting long-term fiscal and contractual terms; the AMAN convention signed in September 2026 was the first

- Nouadhibou Free Zone, operating under its own legal and customs framework for port, fisheries and industrial investment
- Banque Centrale de Mauritanie oversight of the ouguiya (MRU) and an expanding interbank foreign-exchange market, with transactions up 36% to $1.76 billion in 2025
- Partnerships with state companies SMH (hydrocarbons) and SNIM (iron ore) for participation in the gas and mining value chains

### MARKET-ENTRY OBSERVATION

Mauritania in October 2026 combines steady growth, sound macroeconomic management and a new generation of energy projects. Real GDP grew 4.0% in 2025 after 6.3% in 2024, with the non-extractive economy expanding 5.5%, and the IMF projects 4.7% growth in 2026. Exports rose 12.3% to almost $4.3 billion in 2025, helped by the first LNG shipments from the Greater Tortue Ahmeyim project ($237 million), narrowing the trade deficit to $23 million, while foreign-exchange reserves rose 12.6% to $2.21 billion and external debt eased to 37% of GDP. FDI totalled $634 million in 2025 as GTA's first-phase construction was completed, taking the inward stock to $8.2 billion. A new Investment Code in force since 2025, a dedicated Green Hydrogen Code, and a new 42-month IMF programme approved in June 2026 after all end-2025 targets were met give investors a clear and supportive framework.

Mauritania's main structural challenge is its reliance on extractive exports: gold, iron ore and fish account for around 90% of goods exports, so activity and revenues follow commodity prices and mine output, and extractive GDP dipped 1.2% in 2025 as planned lower gold grades at Tasiast took effect. The country is broadening this base in practical ways: GTA LNG reached nameplate capacity in December 2025, SNIM is targeting 15.5 million tonnes in 2026 on the way to 45 million tonnes of capacity by 2031, and the AMAN green hydrogen convention opens a new export industry. Policy buffers are solid, with a fiscal rule now enshrined in law, a budget deficit of only 0.3% of GDP in 2025 and a central bank that acted early, raising its policy rate to 6.5% in May 2026 as inflation rose, reaching 9.3% in September. Each of these shifts creates openings for investors in gas services, mining logistics, renewables and food production.

## INVESTOR RISK & MARKET ACCESS

### KEY ENTRY BARRIERS

| Issue | Potential Impact | Possible Mitigation |
|---|---|---|
| Concentration on extractive exports | Gold, iron ore and fish make up around 90% of goods exports, leaving growth and revenues sensitive to commodity prices and mine schedules | Gas, green hydrogen and SNIM expansion are widening the export base; investors can target the supply chains and services these projects require |
| Regional security in the Sahel | Mauritania has had no jihadist attack on its territory since 2011, but instability in Mali has brought about 320,000 refugees, mostly to the south-east | Most investment sites lie in the west and north; apply standard security planning near the eastern border and draw on strong EU and partner support for stability |
| Inflation uptick and tighter monetary policy | Annual inflation rose to 9.3% in September 2026, its highest since January 2023, and the central bank raised its policy rate to 6.5% in May | The IMF projects inflation easing to 3.0% in 2027; build moderate price assumptions into local operating costs and financing plans |
| Governance and business environment | Governance and transparency remain reform priorities, and the insolvency framework is still developing | Use the 2025 Investment Code's transfer and expropriation guarantees and APIM support; IMF-backed governance and state-enterprise reforms are under way |
| Infrastructure and power access | Electricity reaches about 57% of the population and transport networks are still being built out, adding to project costs | Around 2,200 km of roads are complete or under way and 44% of power comes from renewables, creating opportunities in generation, grids and logistics |
| Timing of large energy projects | GTA Phase 2 is still awaiting a final investment decision and AMAN's decision is expected before 2030 | Phase 1 is performing at or above capacity; position early as a supplier or partner for the next development wave |
| Climate and water stress | More than two-thirds of the territory is desert and the IMF notes frequent climate-related shocks | IMF-supported reforms in water management and climate planning are complete; desalination, irrigation and |

| Issue | Potential Impact | Possible Mitigation |
|---|---|---|
| | | renewables offer investment openings |

### INVESTOR RISK NOTE

Mauritania's risk profile is that of a stable, well-managed economy with improving buffers and a growing pipeline of energy investment. Reserves rose to $2.21 billion at end-2025, the budget is close to balance, around 70% of external debt is owed to multilateral lenders, and the country met all end-2025 IMF targets before securing a new 42-month programme in June 2026. The 2025 Investment Code and the Green Hydrogen Code provide clear legal footing, while the start of LNG exports and record iron ore output show that large projects can be delivered. The main considerations are commodity concentration, the recent rise in inflation and the security situation in neighbouring Mali; Mauritania's record of internal stability, its prompt monetary response and strong international partnerships help mitigate each of these. Investors should apply standard commodity-price and security planning, particularly for projects near the eastern border.

### MARKET ACCESS

Mauritania has been a WTO member since 1995 and was among the first countries to ratify the African Continental Free Trade Area (AfCFTA), opening tariff preferences across the continent. It is a member of the Arab Maghreb Union, signed an association agreement with ECOWAS in 2017 to ease trade with West Africa, and as a least-developed country enjoys duty-free access to the EU under Everything But Arms. The EU is its main partner, and principal export destinations include Canada, China, Europe, Algeria and Switzerland. Iron ore leaves through Nouadhibou, LNG is loaded offshore at the GTA hub, and the Rosso crossing links the country by road to Senegal, giving Mauritania a natural position as a bridge between the Maghreb and West Africa.

## WHO SHOULD THE INVESTOR MEET?

### INSTITUTIONAL LANDSCAPE

| Actor | Why It Matters | Waverley Engagement Angle |
|---|---|---|
| Office of the President (Mohamed Ould Cheikh El Ghazouani) | Sets national strategy and energy and mining policy; re-elected in June 2024 for a second term, working with Prime Minister Mokhtar Ould Djay's government | Primary reference point for strategic direction and major partnerships |
| Agence de Promotion des Investissements en Mauritanie (APIM) | National investment promotion agency with an expanded role under the 2025 Investment Code and a digitised one-stop shop | Standard first point of contact for market entry, incentive approvals and registration |
| Banque Centrale de Mauritanie (BCM) | Monetary authority managing the ouguiya, the policy rate and the interbank foreign-exchange market | Relevant for currency, transfer and banking-sector matters |
| Ministry of Economic Affairs and Development and Ministry of Finance | Separate ministries since September 2025, responsible for development planning, public investment and fiscal policy | Key counterparts for public-private partnerships, tax matters and donor-funded projects |
| Ministry of Energy and Oil and SMH (Société Mauritanienne des Hydrocarbures) | Lead the gas, power and green hydrogen agenda; SMH is Mauritania's national partner in the GTA project | Essential counterparts for any energy-sector engagement |
| SNIM (Société Nationale Industrielle et Minière) | State iron ore producer, which achieved record output in 2025 and is targeting 45 million tonnes of capacity by 2031 | Central partner for mining services, rail and port logistics, and green iron |
| Ministry of Mines and Industry | Oversees mining titles and industrial policy, including gold, iron ore and new mineral projects | Relevant for mining-sector entry and industrial investment |

### CURRENT INTERNATIONAL BUSINESS CHANNELS

The National Union of Mauritanian Employers (UNPM) is the main private-sector body and co-organised a US business mission to Nouakchott in October 2026 covering energy, mining, infrastructure, agriculture, fisheries and the digital economy, while the Chamber of Commerce, Industry and Agriculture of Mauritania provides domestic business liaison. The Mauritanides mining and energy conference and the Nouakchott National Energy Forum are useful meeting points for the resources sector. The European Union, Mauritania's main partner, supports renewable energy, green hydrogen and vocational training, and the IMF, World Bank, IFC and African Development Bank maintain active programmes; the IFC supported the design of the 2025 Investment Code. Operators such as bp, Kosmos Energy and Kinross offer practical insight into operating conditions in the gas and mining sectors.

## INVESTOR PROFILE BEST SUITED

Mauritania best suits investors with a long-term view and sector expertise: energy and oilfield-services companies positioned for GTA operations and future phases; mining, rail and port-logistics investors partnering with SNIM and international gold producers; renewable-energy and green-hydrogen developers drawn by world-class solar and wind resources and the Green Hydrogen Code; and fisheries, agribusiness and food-processing investors serving domestic and West African demand. Development finance institutions and impact investors will find strong openings in power, water and infrastructure, while all investors should build standard commodity-price and regional security planning into their projects.

## FROM INTELLIGENCE TO ENGAGEMENT

STEP 1: Engage APIM and assess incentives under the 2025 Investment Code
Open dialogue with the national investment agency to confirm eligibility for the Code's incentive tiers and to use the one-stop shop for registration and permits.

STEP 2: Map opportunities around the gas and mining anchors
Identify supply, service and logistics openings linked to GTA LNG, SNIM's expansion and the Tasiast mine through early contact with SMH, SNIM and the operators.

STEP 3: Position for the green hydrogen and renewables pipeline
Follow the AMAN convention and other projects under the Green Hydrogen Code, and assess partnership roles in power generation, water and green iron.

STEP 4: Plan currency and financing arrangements
Agree transfer arrangements with local banks under BCM rules and the Code's guarantees, and allow for the higher 2026 interest-rate and inflation environment.

STEP 5: Build security and partner networks into project design
Commission site-specific security assessments for projects near the eastern border and engage UNPM, the EU and development finance partners for co-financing and local insight.